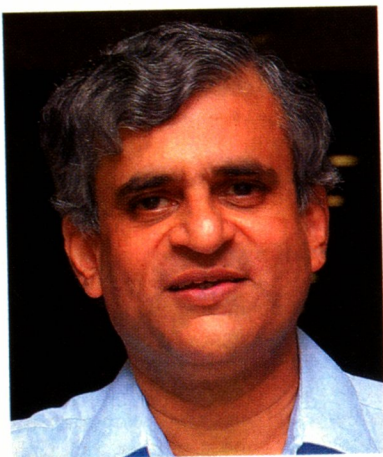


NEW CANVAS

After being immortalised on M.F. Husain's canvas, **Amrita Rao** has bagged a role in acclaimed film-maker Shyam Benegal's next project. "He was always on my wish list of directors. There were no questions to be asked. I just said yes," exclaims Rao, who is paired with *Iqbal* actor Shreyas Talpade in this untitled film. Rao is currently attending Benegal's workshops and "watching DVDs of all his films to understand his work". Hmm. Now all she has to do is act.



THE HINDU

Prized Fighter

Everybody's favourite social scientist, **Palagummi Sainath**, 50, has won this year's Ramon Magsaysay award for journalism, literature and creative communication arts. The rural affairs editor of *The Hindu* has spent over 26 years in journalism, and almost all of them on the road. The grandson of the late president V.V. Giri says "such awards open up issues in the media". They also legitimise this kind of journalism, he says. Especially when the space for it is shrinking.

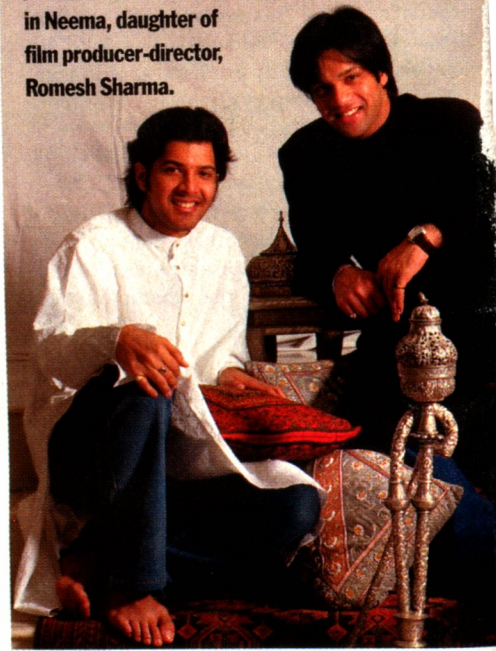
BLUE-EYED GIRL

After a two-year-long wait, **Shreya Sharma** can finally exhale freely for her debut film, *The Blue Umbrella*, in which she plays a village girl. "She was quite confident the first time she faced the camera. It was surprising as she had never been actively involved in school plays," says her father Abhay Sharma. The Class IX student is now keen on a career in films but her father insists that "she will take up only good roles since her studies shouldn't suffer".



Broken Strings

He is a bashful sarod player **Amaan Ali Khan** and she a Kashmiri lawyer, **Avantika Haksar**. They were made-for-each other until cupid cut loose and the engagement was called off. "The reason is personal," says Amaan, even as his younger brother Ayaan has found his match in Neema, daughter of film producer-director, **Romesh Sharma**.



MANPREET ROMANA

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